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Grant Writing Masterclass

Module 8 — Evaluation

Student Course Companion

Name: _____ Organization: _____

Team / Cohort (if applicable): _____

This workbook is your hands-on companion to Module 8. Evaluation is the section that proves your proposal — not just describes it. Complete each section in order. Team prompts appear in green throughout.

Section 1 — Key Terms & Concepts

These are the core concepts for Module 8. Each one maps to a specific part of your evaluation section.

Evaluation	A structured plan for determining whether your program worked. Answers three questions: Did we do what we said we would do? Did it make a difference? And what did we learn from it?
Expected Results (Funding Period)	The specific, measurable changes you project will occur in the people you serve as a direct result of your program during this grant cycle. Not hopes or long-term goals — what you realistically commit to delivering within the grant period.
Evaluation Methodology	Your structured plan for defining, tracking, and measuring success. Includes the tools you will use, the frequency of data collection, who is responsible, and your evaluation timeline.
Activity vs. Outcome	A critical distinction: an activity is what you do (run a 12-week workshop). An outcome is the change that results (80% of participants demonstrate measurable skill improvement). Funders pay for outcomes, not activities.

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Pre- and Post-Assessment	A measurement approach that captures a participant's knowledge, skills, or status at program entry and again at program completion. Provides a before-and-after picture of change that funders find highly credible.
Baseline Data	Information collected before the program begins that establishes a starting point against which to measure change. Essential for pre/post comparisons and for demonstrating the gap your program closes.
Attendance and Participation Records	Data tracking how often participants attend and engage with program sessions. Essential for programs where dosage matters — participants need a minimum level of exposure to benefit.
External Data Sources	Third-party records — school grades, employment records, health screenings, court records — that provide objective measures of program impact when participants provide consent.
Evaluation Calendar	A timeline that specifies when each data collection activity will occur, who is responsible, and when results will be compiled and reported. Demonstrates that evaluation is built into the program structure from the start.
Dissemination	The process of sharing your evaluation results beyond the funder's report — through your annual report, website, newsletters, community presentations, and future grant proposals. Builds public credibility and strengthens future funding.
Program Improvement Loop	The practice of using evaluation data internally to identify what is working, what is not, and where to improve. Signals organizational learning to funders.
Track Record	The documented history of your organization's past outcomes across grant cycles. Built systematically through consistent evaluation. The strongest asset in any future grant application.

Section 2 — Annotated Example

Read the annotated evaluation section below. The right column explains what each element is doing and why it works. As you read, identify which elements your own proposal currently has and which ones are missing.

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Sample: Full Evaluation Section (Sections A, B, and C)

PROPOSAL TEXT	WHY IT WORKS
[A. EXPECTED RESULTS DURING FUNDING PERIOD] <i>During the 12-month grant period, we project the following outcomes for the 90 participants enrolled in the Career Pathways Program: (1) 85% will complete the full 16-week career readiness curriculum; (2) 75% will obtain an industry-recognized certification in their chosen track; (3) 70% will secure a job placement or paid internship within 90 days of program completion; and (4) 60% will remain employed or enrolled in a post-secondary program at the six-month follow-up mark.</i>	→ Four distinct outcomes, not one vague statement → Each has a percentage, a population (90 participants), and a timeframe → Outcomes are sequenced logically: completion → certification → placement → retention → Directly traceable to the program activities described in Module 6
[B. HOW WE WILL MEASURE SUCCESS] <i>Success will be measured through four tools. (1) A career readiness pre- and post-assessment (WorkReady Assessment Tool) administered at intake and program exit to measure skill development across all participants. (2) Weekly attendance records maintained by program coordinators to ensure dosage requirements are met. (3) A 30-day and 90-day post-completion employment survey administered by phone, tracking job placement and retention. (4) For participants who consent, employer verification records at the six-month mark. Data will be collected by the Program Coordinator (baseline and attendance), the Data Manager (surveys and employment tracking), and reviewed quarterly by an external program evaluator from Bright Outcomes Consulting. Baseline data collection begins in Month 1; midpoint analysis occurs in Month 6; final evaluation is completed in Month 12 with a report delivered to the funder by Month 13.</i>	→ Four named tools, each matched to a specific outcome → Pre/post design captures change, not just activity → External evaluator named — adds credibility and independence → Specific roles assigned: Program Coordinator, Data Manager → Evaluation calendar built in: Month 1, 6, 12, 13
[C. HOW RESULTS WILL BE USED AND DISSEMINATED] <i>Evaluation results will be used in four ways. First, they will be compiled into a mid-year progress report and a final outcomes report submitted to this funder. Second, outcome data from this grant</i>	→ All four dissemination channels named: funder reports, future proposals, internal improvement, public sharing → Program improvement trigger is specific: attendance below 80% =

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period will be incorporated directly into future grant applications, building an evidence base for program replication and expansion. Third, results will be reviewed quarterly by program staff and leadership to identify areas for program adjustment — if attendance drops below 80% in any cohort, the program coordinator will conduct participant interviews within two weeks to identify barriers and implement supports. Fourth, aggregate outcomes will be featured in our annual report, e-newsletter, and website, and presented at the Regional Workforce Development Collaborative annual convening in May.

interview within 2 weeks

→ **Public dissemination names a specific venue (Regional Workforce Collaborative convening in May)**

☐ **Team:** As a group: walk through all three sections. Which of the four dissemination channels does your organization currently use? Which one would have the most impact to add before your next proposal cycle?

Section 3 — Before & After Comparisons

Study each pair. The weak version shows what most first drafts look like. The strong version shows what wins funding. Answer the reflection question after each pair.

Comparison 1 — Expected Results

☐ **Weak**

Participants will improve their outcomes and benefit from our services. The community will see positive change as a result of this program. We are committed to making a difference.

☐ **Strong**

During the 12-month grant period: (1) 85% of the 60 enrolled participants will complete all 10 curriculum modules; (2) 78% will demonstrate a statistically significant improvement on the WorkReady Career Readiness Assessment; (3) 70% will secure employment or enroll in post-secondary education within 90 days of program completion.

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□ What three structural elements does the strong version include that are completely absent from the weak version?

□ **Team discussion:** Draft your own expected results using the strong version as a model. Does each result have a percentage, a population count, and a timeframe? If any are missing, the result is not ready.

Comparison 2 — Measurement Tools

□ Weak

We will evaluate the program by collecting feedback from participants at the end of the year. Staff will track how well the program is going and report results to the funder.

□ Strong

Success will be measured through three tools: (1) a pre- and post-assessment using the validated WorkReady tool, administered at intake and program exit; (2) biweekly attendance records maintained by the program coordinator; and (3) a 90-day post-completion phone survey tracking employment status. The Program Coordinator is responsible for assessments and attendance; the Data Manager tracks employment surveys. Baseline data collection begins in Month 1; final evaluation is completed in Month 11 with results submitted to the funder in Month 12.

□ What four things does the strong measurement plan specify that the weak version does not?

□ **Team discussion:** List the measurement tools your organization currently uses. Is each one matched to a specific outcome? Is there a named person responsible for each? Add both to your measurement plan.

Comparison 3 — Dissemination

□ Weak

□ Strong

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We will share our results with the funder in our final report. We are committed to transparency and accountability.

Results will be used in four ways: (1) compiled into mid-year and final funder reports; (2) incorporated into our next grant applications as documented outcome evidence; (3) reviewed quarterly by staff to identify program adjustments — if completion rates drop below 75%, the program manager will conduct interviews within two weeks; and (4) shared publicly in our annual report, e-newsletter, and at the Regional Youth Services Summit in June.

☐ **Why is naming all four dissemination channels — not just funder reporting — important to a funder reading your proposal?**

☐ **Team discussion:** *Which of the four channels does your organization currently use? Identify one new channel you could realistically add in the next grant cycle and assign someone to own it.*

Section 4 — Your Evaluation Section Builder

Complete each part in order. By the end of this section you will have a complete first draft of your evaluation section, ready to refine and submit.

Part A — Expected Results During the Funding Period

Project the specific outcomes you expect to achieve during this grant cycle. Each result must include a percentage, a population count, and a timeframe.

☐ **Expected Result 1 (completion or participation rate):**

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- ☐ Expected Result 2 (skill, knowledge, or behavioral change):
-

- ☐ Expected Result 3 (employment, enrollment, or longer-term outcome):
-

- ☐ Expected Result 4 (retention or follow-up outcome, if applicable):
-

★Example — Expected result format:

By [end of grant period], [X]% of the [# participants] enrolled in [program name] will [specific change], as tracked by [measurement tool / data source].

☐ **Tip:** Your expected results should align directly with the goals and objectives you wrote in Module 5. If there is a disconnect between what your program is designed to do and what you are promising here, the funder will notice.

☐ **Team:** Share your expected results as a group. Apply the following test to each one: Does it have a number? Does it name the population? Does it include a timeframe? If any answer is no, rewrite before moving on.

Part B — How You Will Define and Measure Success

Answer each prompt below, then transfer your answers into the Measurement Planning Table.

- ☐ In one sentence, define what success looks like for this program at the end of the grant period:
-

- ☐ Measurement Tool 1: Name the tool, what it measures, and when it will be administered:
-

- ☐ Measurement Tool 2: Name the tool, what it measures, and when it will be administered:

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☐ **Measurement Tool 3 (if applicable):**

☐ **Who is responsible for collecting and tracking evaluation data? (Name the role or person for each tool.)**

☐ **Will you use an external evaluator? If so, who? If not, describe how you will ensure objectivity in your data collection.**

MEASUREMENT PLANNING TABLE — Complete one row for each outcome.

Outcome / Objective	Measurement Tool	When Collected	Who Collects It	Baseline Available?

☐ **Tip:** Match your measurement tool to your stated outcome. If your objective says participants will increase reading proficiency, your tool should be a recognized reading assessment — not a general satisfaction survey. The tighter the match, the more credible your evaluation.

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EVALUATION CALENDAR — Complete the table below to map your data collection timeline.

Evaluation Milestone	Target Date / Month	Responsible Role
Baseline / intake assessments administered		
Attendance tracking begins		
Midpoint participant surveys collected		
Midpoint data review and program adjustment		
Interim funder report submitted		
Final assessments / post-program measures collected		
External evaluation completed (if applicable)		
Final data compiled and analyzed		
Final funder report submitted		
Results shared publicly (newsletter, website, presentations)		

☐ **Team:** Assign each evaluation milestone a responsible person and confirm the target date matches your program and timetable from Module 6. A calendar without owners is not a plan.

Part C — How Results Will Be Used and Disseminated

☐ **Funder Reporting:** Describe the reports you will submit (midpoint, final) and their projected submission dates.

☐ **Future Grant Applications:** How will this grant cycle's data strengthen your next proposal? What outcome evidence are you building toward?

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☐ **Program Improvement:** How will you use data internally? Name a specific trigger that would prompt a program adjustment (e.g., if attendance drops below X%, we will do Y within Z weeks).

☐ **Public Dissemination:** Where will you share results publicly? Name at least one specific venue, publication, or event.

☐ **Write your full dissemination paragraph combining all four channels:**

☐ **Team discussion:** Read your dissemination paragraphs aloud as a group. Does each one describe a plan or a commitment? Replace any vague language with specific channels, dates, and names.

★Example — Dissemination paragraph structure:

Evaluation results will be used in four ways: (1) compiled into [midpoint / final] reports submitted to the funder by [date]; (2) incorporated into future grant applications as documented outcome evidence for [program area]; (3) reviewed [quarterly / monthly] by program staff to guide adjustments — if [specific trigger], [specific response] will occur within [timeframe]; and (4) shared publicly through [annual report / e-newsletter / website] and presented at [specific event or venue] in [month/year].

Section 5 — Module 8 Self-Audit Checklist

Check every box you can honestly say is true for your current evaluation section. Unchecked boxes are revision priorities.

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Section A — Expected Results

- ☐ I have written at least three specific expected results for the grant period — not vague statements about impact.
- ☐ Each expected result includes a percentage target, the number of people affected, and a timeframe.
- ☐ My expected results align directly with the goals and objectives I wrote in Module 5.
- ☐ My expected results reflect what my program is actually designed to deliver — not aspirational long-term outcomes.

Section B — Measurement Plan

- ☐ I have named at least two specific measurement tools and matched each one to a stated outcome.
- ☐ I am using a pre- and post-assessment design for at least one outcome that measures knowledge, skills, or behavioral change.
- ☐ I have named the person or role responsible for collecting data for each tool.
- ☐ I have established an evaluation timeline: when baseline data is collected, when midpoint review occurs, and when final evaluation is completed.
- ☐ I have addressed how I will ensure objectivity — either through an external evaluator or a structured internal review process.

Section C — Dissemination

- ☐ I have described how results will be included in funder reports (midpoint and final), with projected submission dates.
- ☐ I have explained how this grant cycle's data will strengthen future grant applications.
- ☐ I have described a specific internal program improvement process, including a trigger and a response.
- ☐ I have named at least one specific public dissemination channel (annual report, newsletter, website, event) and a timeline.

Coherence

- ☐ My evaluation section is consistent with my goals and objectives from Module 5.
- ☐ My measurement tools are aligned with the program activities I described in Module 6.

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- ☐ My evaluation calendar is consistent with the timetable I built in Module 6.
- ☐ A funder reading my evaluation section would feel confident that I know what I'm trying to achieve and have a credible plan to prove it.

My revision priorities before the next module:

☐ **Team:** Assign each revision item a team member and a due date. Write names next to each item above before leaving this session.

*"A strong evaluation section is the difference
between a proposal that describes a program
and a proposal that proves one."*

— Grant Writing Masterclass, Module 8